

UP IN THE VALLEY
(from top) A musical session at Jhelum Cafe, Srinagar; singers Faheem Abdullah; and Ahmer Javed





here long enough, seen what we have, how can you be untouched? Most people here are suffering from PTSD. That cannot go unnoticed," says Javed.

For Faheem Abdullah, 25, growing up in Kashmir has meant living in constant fear. "But at some point, you become immune," he says. Abdullah learnt how to sing holy verses from the Quran at an early age, but he then quickly graduated to *nazm*s and *ghazal*s. It was around 2012, when Abdullah saw the popularity of Arijit Singh and Mohit Chauhan soar, that he decided he, too, could pursue music full-time. Though he did not know how to play an instrument, he says composing has always come naturally to him: "My friends play instruments. They have collaborated with me."

Some of the songs coming out of the Valley reflect the region's political turmoil and its effect on the mental health of the Kashmiri people

Like Javed, Abdullah, too, was born in Srinagar. He believes that while it's important to write about the conflict around him, he also has an equal responsibility to reflect the inner conflict of young Kashmiris. "I think it's always been the job of art to reflect society. Like how Premchand wrote about caste, G. Kalyan Rao wrote about untouchability in Andhra Pradesh, I try to balance the conflicts of the inside and outside."

When asked if Kashmiri artists feel burdened by the responsibility to reflect the truths of their region, Javed gives a realistic, pragmatic response: "I know I can't single-handedly bring about change, that's something the people will have to do. But I think I can use my art and platform to make something that could inspire someone to do the 'right' thing. As a musician, my job is that of a storyteller. Especially, *jinki kahaaniyaan sunaayi nahin deti* [Especially, those whose stories we don't get to hear]."

Of late, artists like Javed and Abdullah have also found a champion in a local business, Jhelum Café. Co-founded by cousins Asim and Adil Khan in 2019, the café soon became a live music venue, a haven for Kashmir's emerging music talent. Adil recounts one emotionally-charged moment: "Ali Saifuddin was singing when some mischievous elements in the crowd tried to disrupt the performance. After they were escorted out, Ali sang 'Aasan Gindaan'. It hyped everyone up. We all became emotional."

As someone who does not censor himself, Abdullah says musicians must be free to raise their concerns in any form they choose. "I know how expression works, and I have the option to be direct or not. It's one of the biggest tools at the disposal of any artist: symbolism. It is, ultimately, in my hands, what I put out." ■

–Tatsam Mukherjee